

competition. Should he get to North America — the tournament is being held simultaneously in Canada, the USA and Mexico — Sarpreet will become the first player of Indian origin to compete at a World Cup since Vikash Rao Dhorasoo, who was part of the French team that finished runners-up at the 2006 World Cup.

“As a kid I looked up to a lot of those guys who were part of the team that qualified. You’d look at these people and you think it’s so amazing and you just want to be there. As a kid you always dream of playing in a World Cup. But you’d never really think it could happen to you. Now I’m fortunate enough to be in that same position where I think maybe other kids, like I once was, will look up to me and want to be in the same position,” he says.

Typical Punjabi family

Football might not seem like the first option for a lot of Indian-origin kids in New Zealand — the community sees far more representation in cricket and hockey. But growing up in Auckland, where his parents, originally from Jalandhar, ran a grocery store, Sarpreet says he always loved football.

“I’m from a very typical Punjabi family with a lot of uncles and aunties and cousins. We always used to play backyard cricket, a bit of basketball. Softball was pretty big at school and I played rugby as well — but not the tackling kind because I was always a bit small. But out of all the sports I played, football was the one I enjoyed the most. My elder brother and my uncle played socially as well, so perhaps some of that rubbed off on me,” he says.

It wasn’t the easiest being a football fan, Sarpreet admits. “I used to watch a lot of Premier League games as a kid and with New Zealand being on the other side of the world, the timing was completely opposite for us. So me and my brother would be up at 2 or 3 in the morning, just watching Chelsea and Manchester United

games,” he says.

But Sarpreet was more than just a fan. At seven, his mother Sarabjit put him into his first club. He’s grateful for that opportunity. “I think sometimes with Punjabi parents, maybe they’re a bit too strict on their kids or they want to turn their focus to education. I was put in an academy when I was younger and my mother would drive me to practice. That was a support that not every Punjabi kid got. My two elder siblings didn’t get that. But that opportunity to train at a club really helped to shape me,” he says.

Starting out at the Wynrs Wynton Rufer Soccer academy at the age of seven, he joined Wellington Phoenix Academy in 2015 (**below**), Sarpreet says he figured out early on that he had some potential. “I think from a young age, like around 11 or 12, I kind of knew that I was above others. I often used to play above my age group. I wasn’t the physically biggest

player then, or even now, but in terms of my football capabilities, I was good enough to be able to cope with higher age groups. And then when I was around 15 or 16, I started to enter the national age-group teams. I guess that’s when I started to realise that something’s possible from this,” he says.

Sarpreet was part of the New Zealand team at the U17 Oceania Cup and U20 World Cups, and his performance in the latter — he scored one goal as New Zealand reached the last 16 — was good enough for clubs in Europe to take note. In 2019, Sarpreet was picked by German giants Bayern Munich, becoming the first New Zealand player since Wynton Rufer (Werder Bremen) to be signed by a Bundesliga team.

“It was a really incredible moment, to be fair, because not many people go from New Zealand directly into Bayern. Even though I was playing for the second team initially, it was still a huge step up. I felt very motivated to want to do more. I realised just how these elite players lived their day-to-day lives, because very quickly I was promoted to train with the first team. I didn’t play as many games [he would only play twice for the main team], but just the experience you gain from training is invaluable,” he says.

Challenge for an outsider

Being one of the few New Zealand players at the highest level of European football came with its own share of challenges.

“Obviously, you’re so far away from home. I think as Punjabi people, sometimes we’re also not the most outspoken — or me anyway, you know — so sometimes you can feel lonely as a footballer. And there is the pressure of having to perform. If you don’t perform, then there’s a huge amount of pressure,” he says.

